

Parshas Bamidbar

פרשת במדבר - תשע"ט

Rabbi Shalom Rosner ♦ 5779

Sefer Bamidbar holds a central paradox: *how do we find order in the wilderness?* Each of the six highlights below traces a thread of Rabbi Rosner's answer.

1 • Every Sefer Has Its Own Soul

The *Rishonim* each offer a distinct lens. Bamidbar is *Chumash HaPekudim* — the Book of Countings — yet far more than a census. It spans **year one** through **year forty** with nearly thirty-eight silent years between.

כָּל סֵפֶר יֵשׁ לוֹ עֵינָן בְּפָנָי עֲצָמוֹ,
עֲצָמוֹת וְתַכְלִית מִיּוֹחֶדֶת.

Opening — 0:00

2 • Bitachon Unlocks Torah

Trust in God leads to deeper Torah understanding because Torah cannot be acquired through intellect alone — Hashem must open the gates. The *midbar* strips away every crutch, leaving only Hashem.

מִדַּת הַבְּטָחוֹן
מְבִיאָה לְהַבְנִית הַתּוֹרָה.

4:08 — Darkei Mussar

3 • Order Within the Wilderness

Midbar is *hefker* — ownerless, formless. **Pekudim** is the opposite: each person counted, each tribe placed, each flag raised. That is the sefer's challenge.

הַמִּפְקָד הוּא בִּיטּוּיֹו הַמְּבַהֵק שֶׁל אֲרָגוֹן וְסֹדֶר - אִישׁ עַל מַחְנֵהוּ וְאִישׁ עַל דָּגְלוֹ.

"To have order in *hefkerus*. To be in a *makom hefker*, and yet be *mufkad* — counted, known, placed." 19:56

4 • Flags Like Angels — Love Made Visible

Why flags? Flags are *physical*; angels are spiritual. The Midrash finds the answer in *Shir HaShirim*: “His banner over me is love.” The flag is not military — it is an expression of Hashem’s love, making each tribe **recognisable**.

חֲבֵה גְדוּלָה חֲבָבָן
הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא
שֶׁעֲשָׂאָם דְּגָלִים
כְּמִלְאֵי הַשָּׁרִת
כְּדִי שְׂיִהוּ נִכְרִים.

39:54 — *Midrash Rabbah*

5 • No Star Without a Purpose

Every tribe has its own gift. Every Jew — like every star — was created for a **specific, unrepeatable mission**. Some excel in *tefillah*, some in Torah, some in *chesed*. None is redundant.

אֵין כּוֹכָב בְּלֹא מִטְרָה.
לְכָל כּוֹכָב יֵשׁ יַעֲוִד וְתַפְקִיד מִיַּיחָד שֶׁלְשֵׁמוֹ נִבְרָא.
מוֹנֶה מִסֵּפֶר לְכוֹכָבִים – לְכֹלָם שְׁמוֹת יִקְרָא. (תהלים קמז)

“The second we were born was when Hashem decided the world **cannot exist without us** anymore.” 40:01

6 • The Silence of the Sdei Chemed

A young scholar in Bukhara — later the *Sdei Chemed* — was falsely accused. He chose **silence** over vindication. From that moment his learning soared. To be *mevater* — to yield what is rightfully yours — may be the greatest *zechus* we can offer.
“From the moment he decided to remain silent, he began to see extraordinary success in his studies.”

הַכּוֹבֵשׁ אֶת פִּי
זוֹכֶה לְסִיעָתָא דְשִׁמְיָא
בְּלִמּוּדוֹ.

Sdei Chemed, 1834–1905

וַיְדַבֵּר ה' אֶל-מֹשֶׁה בְּמִדְבַּר סִינַי

“And Hashem spoke to Moshe in the Wilderness of Sinai.” (Bamidbar 1:1)